🚜 U.S. Food & Farm Facts: Reading

Ag Science 1 · Unit 3 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with US Food and Farm Facts Notes + Quiz, Food and Facts presentation, The Future of Farming, Biggest Little Farm, Ag Literacy Poster

Name: _____

Who Feeds America?

Farm and ranch families are only about 2% of the U.S. population, but each U.S. farmer feeds about 154 people. Together, U.S. farmers produce about 2.1 trillion pounds of food a year. About 97% of U.S. farms are owned by families, big and small.

Farmers grow more food using fewer resources than ever. Careful stewardship of soil and water helped cropland erosion drop nearly 50% since 1982. Americans spend the smallest share of their income on food of any country, about 10%, but of each dollar spent on food, the farmer gets only about 16 cents.

The United States sells farm products around the world. The top buyers are China, Canada and Mexico, and the top export is soybeans. The U.S. grows about a third of the world's corn and soybeans. Agriculture also gives us much more than food: lumber, medicine, latex gloves, shampoo, crayons, baseballs and fuel.

By 2050 there may be 9 to 10 billion people, so farmers must grow much more food. Biotechnology improves crops so they have higher yields and fewer pests and diseases. Precision agriculture uses GPS and auto-steer to raise yields, lower costs and use fewer chemicals. Vertical farms grow crops in stacked layers indoors.

For the Ag Literacy Poster, students teach one fact about agriculture and bust a common myth. Good posters check facts with trusted sources like the USDA or Washington Ag Statistics, and credit every source.

Check your reading

1. About how many people does one U.S. farmer feed?

2. Of each $1 spent on food, how much does the farmer get?

3. Name one technology that will help feed 10 billion people.